altitude lakes of turquoise and jade, waiting and planning for the right moment to recover his birthright. ‘At this time,’ he wrote, ‘fate afflicted us with much suffering. But we prayed for strength, as the gift of victory and of kingship lies only with God. By His grace, our intention was that from the moment of mounting the throne, we would so rule our subjects with justice and mercy, that they should live in happiness within the shade of our protecting wings. For the purpose of kingship is to watch over the people, and to free the weak from oppression.’[22]

His moment came three years later, in 1803, when sectarian rioting broke out: ‘The people of Kabul’, wrote the Shah, ‘remembered the gentleness and generosity of my brother Zaman’s governance; and they compared it to the insolence of the usurper and his ruffianly troops. They had had enough, and had recourse to the pretext of religious differences in order to obtain some change. The quarrel between Sunni and Shia blazed again, and soon there were riots in the streets of Kabul.’[23]

The fighting was between the Shia Qizilbash and their Sunni Afghan neighbours. According to a Sunni source,

> a Qizilbash rogue seduced a young Sunni boy who lived in Kabul into going home with him. He invited some other pederasts to take part in this loathsome business and they performed a number of obscene acts on the helpless lad. At the end of several days, during which they plied him with drugs and alcohol, they threw him out into the street. The boy went home and told his father what had happened. His father, in turn, demanded justice . . . The boy’s family assembled at the Pul-i-Khishti Mosque on Friday, with their heads and feet bared, and their pockets turned inside out. They stood the boy beneath the pulpit and called on the chief preacher to redress the wrong. The preacher then declared a war against the Qizilbash.[24]

Most serious Afghan feuds tend to involve close blood-relations, and the ‘usurper’ in this case was Shah Shuja’s estranged half-brother, Shah Mahmoud. When he refused to punish the overmighty Qizilbash who made up both his bodyguard and administrative elite, outraged Sunni tribesmen poured into Kabul from the surrounding hills and besieged the walled Qizilbash compound. In the chaos, Shah Shuja arrived from Peshawar as a champion of Sunni orthodoxy, freed one brother – Shah Zaman – from imprisonment, then locked up the other – Shah Mahmoud – in his stead. He forgave all who had rebelled against Shah Zaman, with the single exception of the clan of the Shinwari chieftain responsible for blinding his brother: ‘The officers arrested the culprit, and his supporters, and razed his fort to the ground. They looted everything and dragged the man to Shuja’s court.